and benign messages unrelated to Wirathu, but the moment that first video ended, the Facebook algorithm immediately began auto-playing a hate-filled Wirathu video, in order to keep users glued to the screen. In the case of one such Wirathu video, internal research at Facebook estimated that 70 per cent of the video's views came from such auto-playing algorithms. The same research estimated that, altogether, 53 per cent of all videos watched in Myanmar were being auto-played for users by algorithms. In other words, people weren't choosing what to see. The algorithms were choosing for them.[20]

But why did the algorithms decide to promote outrage rather than compassion? Even Facebook's harshest critics don't claim that Facebook's human managers wanted to instigate mass murder. The executives in California harboured no ill will toward the Rohingya and, in fact, barely knew they existed. The truth is more complicated, and potentially more alarming. In 2016–17, Facebook's business model relied on maximising 'user engagement'. This referred to the time users spent on the platform, as well as to any action they took such as clicking the like button or sharing a post with friends. As user engagement increased, so Facebook collected more data, sold more advertisements and captured a larger share of the information market. In addition, increases in user engagement impressed investors, thereby driving up the price of Facebook's stock. The more time people spent on the platform, the richer Facebook became. In line with this business model, human managers provided the company's algorithms with a single overriding goal: increase user engagement. The algorithms then discovered by experimenting on millions of users that outrage generated engagement. Humans are more likely to be engaged by a hate-filled conspiracy theory than by a sermon on compassion. So in pursuit of user engagement, the algorithms made the fateful decision to spread outrage.[21]

Ethnic-cleansing campaigns are never the fault of just one party. There is plenty of blame to share between plenty of responsible parties. It should be clear that hatred toward the Rohingya predated Facebook's entry to Myanmar and that the greatest share of blame for the 2016–17 atrocities lies on the shoulders of humans like Wirathu and the Myanmar military chiefs, as well as the ARSA leaders who sparked that round of violence. Some responsibility also belongs to the Facebook engineers and executives who coded the algorithms, gave them too much power and failed to moderate them. But crucially, the algorithms themselves are also to blame. By trial